

MOBILE ACTION
Protesters at Jantar Mantar record the scene with their phones, Jul. 21

ARUN KUMAR

said. "Today, I'm here for the future of my 10-year-old daughter." The root cause now belongs to his daughter too—a grievance bequeathed prematurely.

It may have started as a protest about leaks in the NEET paper. But, in a matter of days, it has become something larger: a generation asking to be heard. The police, if they approached the dense mass of protesters, were greeted with chants of "loser, loser!". "Let them pass, ignore them," came the announcement from the stage. "The whole world is watching them. They know what they have done to us."

The old iconography of Indian dissent lives on. Bhagat Singh posters hanged from the railings; Che Guevara's faraway look leaps out of an image taped to a lamp post; Gandhi watched affably from a banner strung between trees. But these images were just the backdrop. The loudest language at Jantar Mantar was something else—of memes, reels, livestreams, selfie videos, hashtags scrawled on cardboard beside hand-drawn slogans.

You can watch the changing grammar of protest in real time: every few minutes, someone grabbed a fellow protester for a quick interview. "One minute, we're live. Just say why you came," said one. One woman finished recording a reel, then turned her phone around to watch someone else's. "The whole movement is driven by social media," said Saurav Das, spokesperson for the Cockroach Janta Party. "People are coming here and finding out for themselves what the truth is. Time's up for traditional media."

The CJP claims its Instagram account was banned. But that's just one account. "*Utth be s**ley, bahut ho gaya tera* (Get up—you've had enough)"—a viral meme reportedly quotes a policeman as he hauled up the fasting activist Sonam Wangchuk at Jantar Mantar on July 18. Since then, social media has been flooded with protesters turning those rude words into a protest slogan, spawning newer ones. "My Ex and Modi are Heartless", winked a hand-made poster brandished by a young man as police watched on. "The future of our democracy depends not on how it treats those who agree with it, but on how it treats its young citizens when they dare to speak with courage, hope and conviction," says Wangchuk.

Deepak Kunju came all the way from Dantewada, Chhattisgarh, with a friend to do just that. His demand sounded painfully modest: "You cannot give jobs, at least hold exams properly so that children can stand on their own feet." A pause later, he added, "At least admit you are wrong." ■

—with Anjum Sharma



"If you cannot give jobs, then hold exams properly so that children can stand on their own feet. At least, admit you are wrong"

— **DEEPAK KUNJU,** *Unemployed, Chhattisgarh*